

its MPs. The party asked for early disclosure of the details of the cash-for-vote scam by the parliamentary committee looking into the allegations. Two days later, rivals Lalu Prasad Yadav and Ram Vilas Paswan closed ranks and joined Mulayam Singh Yadav to burn another CD to "show that it was the BJP that had bribed the MPs".

The sting stories revolve around Amar Singh and his aide Sanjeev Saxena, BJP leader Arun Jaitley, BJP MPs Ashok Argal, Faggan Singh Kulaste, Mahavir Bhagora and Congress leader

received one crore)". Jaitley alleges that Saxena used his mobile phone (9811721499) to call Amar Singh's landline (24616827) to confirm the receipt of advance money by the BJP MPs. He added that Saxena had used the phone till as late as July 20 to inform the media of a press conference which Amar Singh held to announce the "defection" of BJP MP Brijbhushan Sharan Singh.

Bharati's sting, however, had the shortest shelf life as a telltale sign pointed that the sting was cooked up well after the trust vote. The CD



TOUR DE FOES

DATE: 04-08-08

SHIPRA DAS

Long time antagonists came together to "show that it was the BJP that had bribed the MPs".

RESULT: New sting CDs weakens the BJP assault.

Ahmed Patel. The successive stings turned out to be difficult to digest as MPs like Kulaste were seen speaking on behalf of both the sides in an inimitable double role. Every CD strung together a number of sting operations, convenient voice-overs and grainy visuals. And, the truth seemed to slip away somewhere in between. Though not many in public know the details of the original sting, the BJP, which was part of the action, handed over to the parliamentary panel the transcript of the CNN-IBN sting and telephone records of Saxena who allegedly handed over Rs 1 crore cash to a BJP MP.

According to the transcripts, Argal allegedly confirms to Amar Singh that the money offered to the three MPs as advance for staying away from the trust vote had reached them. "*Ek crore prapt ho gaya. Ek poori prapt ho gaya* (We have

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VOICES

"We are shocked that a person like Arun Jaitley would do something like a sting. This is equal to hiding a crime".

MULAYAM SINGH YADAV, SP PRESIDENT

"SAXENA'S SON HAD MENTIONED AMAR SINGH'S OFFICIAL ADDRESS AS HIS FATHER'S ADDRESS."

ARUN JAITLEY,
BJP GENERAL SECRETARY

"Saxena went away with Shahid Siddiqui the day he quit SP and joined BSP."

AMAR SINGH,
SP GENERAL SECRETARY

"The three BJP MPs should undergo a narco test to ascertain the truth."

LALU PRASAD YADAV,
RJD PRESIDENT

"IF THERE IS A NEED FOR A NARCO-ANALYSIS TEST OF ANYBODY IN THE CASH-FOR-VOTE SCAM, IT IS OF SANJEEV SAXENA."

RAVI SHANKAR PRASAD,
BJP SPOKESPERSON

shows Saxena reaching former SP leader Shahid Siddiqui's Nizamuddin home and later emerging out with a paper in his hand. Then the video moves on to Jaitley's official residence at Ashoka Road as Saxena enters the house and later comes out carrying a bag. Then Saxena is shown driving to Argal's Ferozeshah Road residence and goes inside with the bag and comes out empty-handed, which is perhaps meant to prove that the cash has been delivered. In the CD, Kulaste was also seen to be telling that he has never met Amar Singh.

But there are gaping holes in every story. The footage of Argal's house showed a hoarding in front of his residence congratulating the MP for turning down the bribe, offered to abstain from the vote, indicating that the CD was shot after the trust vote. "Bharati appeared to be a political and religious person. That she could stoop so low to be-

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